Batch 5: the Ch1–5 style pass, before and after

2026-11-10. The Line Editor worked on copies in `runs/qa/2026-11-10-batch5/`. Nothing is in the book yet. All six chapters pass every hard check.

What changed, measured

Ch1

Avg words/sentence: 9.1 → 10.8

Sentences of 6 words or fewer: 41% → 30%

Ch2

Avg words/sentence: 9.0 → 11.5

Sentences of 6 words or fewer: 38% → 24%

Ch3

Avg words/sentence: 8.9 → 11.7

Sentences of 6 words or fewer: 40% → 22%

Ch4

Avg words/sentence: 8.9 → 12.6

Sentences of 6 words or fewer: 43% → 19%

Ch5

Avg words/sentence: 9.2 → 12.0

Sentences of 6 words or fewer: 49% → 22%

Ch11–16, for comparison

Avg words/sentence: 11.1–12.5

Sentences of 6 words or fewer: 15–27%

Ch1–5 now read in the same range as the later chapters. Each chapter got 25–31 line edits, and Ch2–5 dropped about half of their section dividers.

Kept, word for word

- The Three-Second Window, the Four D's ("Defense. Deny. Downplay. Deflect."), the view from above, care without contagion. - The fence and nails, the cascade, the soup scene. - Every quotation, and all your own stories: grandfather, father, mother, "The Mistake I Made First". - The closes of Ch1 ("Use it."), Ch2 and Ch4. - Your earlier rulings: Q028 "That's not loving her. That's adding to her weight." (Ch2), Q006 "Acting on anger isn't strength. It's the absence of it." (Ch4), and Q005's in-the-moment question (Ch1). The pass had cut the first two; I restored them.

Samples

Ch1 - Before: "Not the big fights. Not the hard years or the good ones. The window. Who you are…" - After: "Who you are in those three seconds matters more than the big fights, or the hard years and the good ones.

It’s the husband you’ve been becoming, mostly without knowing it.”

Ch2 - Before: “Her mood. Her stress. What she’s carrying… None of it is yours to govern. It’s external. Outside of you. You hope it goes well. Of course you do.” - After: “Her mood, her stress, and what she’s carrying when you walk through the door aren’t yours to govern. They’re outside of you, and of course you hope her day goes well.”

Ch3 - Before: “Your wife is not irrational. She’s working from… In some cases, a more accurate set. She has the outside view… You don’t.” - After: “Your wife is working from a different set of observations than you, and sometimes a more accurate one. She sees your behavior from the outside, and you can’t.”

Ch4 - Before: “You reclassify her as the threat the system was designed to handle. Not

consciously. Not deliberately… She isn't the threat." - After: "…without meaning to, you start treating her as the threat. From where she's standing, she's just your wife, and she's getting heat meant for an enemy."

Ch5 - Before: "You're right. She's wrong. The point is scored. The marriage is slightly colder." - After: "You're right, she's wrong, the point is scored, and the marriage is a little colder for it."

New: one sentence of her side per chapter

Each is drawn from what the chapter already says, with no new facts. - **Ch1:** "From where she's standing, she said one thing and got something sharper back." - **Ch2** (in the cascade): "She only said one thing, and she got your whole day back." - **Ch4:** "From

where she’s standing, she’s just your wife, and she’s getting heat meant for an enemy.” - **Ch5:** “She came to say one thing and ends up answering for something else.”

Softened claims

- “always” → “usually” (Ch3, Ch5). - “never” → “almost never” (Ch1). - “Most couples never return to it” → “It’s common never to come back to it” (Ch5).

One ruling needed: Ch15’s opening (Q058)

Ch15 now opens on the scene: “It usually starts small. She says something with an edge…”. The orientation (“Warmth is easy on a good day…”) comes right after it.

The voice spec says **“Orient before the scene.”** The Line Editor argues “It usually

starts small” works as the orientation.

My recommendation: approve it as an exception for Ch15 only. If you’d rather keep the rule, I’ll put the orientation sentence first again and keep the cut “Each one has an answer” list.

Still to come

- Your three stories for Ch3, Ch4 and Ch5 (the interview questions). - When the stories arrive, they go into these new versions.